



Figure 2: The schema(s)

The way to specifications

The journey to deliver better APIs using open source starts with “communicating APIs via specifications.” If the team developing a feature (or features) is able to understand the specifications better, it gets into a good position not only to develop, but also pass the requests to the entire community of developers better!

Choosing specifications over a doc is the first choice developer teams need to make. Of course, a spreadsheet might look more tempting to deploy as it doesn’t come with a lot of rules, but a specification can offer the same benefits and a lot more, such as conformance to a format. It’s important to conform to a format, as it helps to choose one that is similar to an API. Spreadsheets, on the other hand, contain plain text. A format, whether in JSON/YAML, or anything else, is much closer to an API than plain text.

Next comes the clarity derived from schema objects, which are basically defined as logical structures created by users. Objects such as tables or indexes, which hold data in many cases, also consist of a definition. In the Dolby Media Analyze OpenAPI, `RequestError` is a schema object defined as shown in Figure 1.

Schema objects can be defined, and this will resolve the error response parsing issues the team faces. Figure 2 shows an example of a defined schema object. Schema validations on the specification help ensure at least one successful response is defined for a path. There can be a lot of other validations on the schema too. Tooling like documentation, code generation, mock servers can be used to support the specifications further.

These specifications, in short, act as a blueprint for APIs, which can be of great help in describing the overall structure of an API.

“Spreadsheets served us well in the information age, but as enterprises wrestle with their digital transformation, they are realising they need a much more precise set of human and machine-readable tools that can track the exponential increase in data being produced each day. These specifications now help teams keep up with the perpetual pace of change and remain competitive in today’s ever-evolving and shifting digital landscape,” says Postman chief evangelist Kin Lane. 

This article is based on a talk given by Meenakshi Dhanani, developer advocate, Postman, at OSI 2021.

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